



— OFFICIAL —
**SCHOOL &
TEACHER
AWARDS
HANDBOOK**

*Leave It Better
Than You Found It*



**NEW YORK STUDENT
SUMMER CHALLENGE**

PRESENTED BY

Frantz Coutard



◆ PROFESSIONAL SCHOOL EDITION ◆

OFFICIAL SCHOOL & TEACHER AWARDS HANDBOOK

Leave It Better Than You Found It

This handbook explains how schools, principals, and teachers become eligible for recognition through the Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge.

OFFICIAL USE

For official school, principal, teacher, and competition administration use The handbook is written to support clear understanding, consistent expectations, and fair administration.

Publication Information

OFFICIAL SCHOOL & TEACHER AWARDS HANDBOOK

Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge

Presented by Frantz Coutard

Official Edition - 2026

USE OF THIS HANDBOOK

This handbook explains how schools, principals, and teachers become eligible for recognition through the Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge.

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Introduction: Purpose of This Handbook

The Official School & Teacher Awards Handbook explains how schools, principals, and teachers become eligible for recognition through the Leave It Better Than You Found It New York Student Summer Challenge. Unlike student scholarships, which are determined through independent judging, school and teacher awards are calculated automatically by the official competition platform using verified participation and engagement data.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand the purpose of the handbook. - Learn why school and teacher recognition is separate from student judging. - Establish a common standard for transparency.	- Student scholarships are judged independently. - School, Principal, and Teacher Awards are platform-calculated. - The handbook explains how recognition is earned.

CORE PRINCIPLE

Every student deserves the opportunity to compete. Every teacher deserves recognition for inspiring students. Every school deserves the opportunity to be rewarded for creating a culture of innovation and community engagement.

Chapter 1: Why School & Teacher Awards Exist

The challenge was designed to recognize more than outstanding student ideas. It also encourages schools, principals, and teachers to build a culture where students are inspired to think critically, solve real-world problems, and make a positive impact in their communities.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
– Understand why separate award categories exist. – Learn the purpose of School, Principal, and Teacher Awards. – Recognize how participation strengthens educational opportunity.	– Student Awards recognize innovation and problem-solving. – School Awards recognize participation, leadership, and engagement. – Teacher Awards recognize educators who inspire and support student success.

CORE PRINCIPLE

Every student deserves the opportunity to compete. Every teacher deserves recognition for inspiring students. Every school deserves the opportunity to be rewarded for creating a culture of innovation and community engagement.

Chapter 2: Two Award Systems, One Shared Mission

The competition uses two independent award systems. The first recognizes individual student achievement through creativity, innovation, research, and practical problem-solving. The second recognizes school leadership and educational engagement by encouraging schools and teachers to involve as many students as possible in meaningful learning experiences.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand the two official award systems. - Learn who evaluates each award category. - Promote transparency throughout the competition.	- Student Awards are determined by Independent Official Judges. - School, Principal, and Teacher Awards are determined by the Official Competition Platform. - Each award category recognizes a different type of achievement.

Official Award Structure

Award System	Purpose	Determined By
Student Achievement Awards	Recognize creativity, innovation, research, and practical solutions.	Independent Official Judges
School Leadership & Participation Awards	Recognize schools, principals, and teachers that inspire participation and educational engagement.	Official Competition Platform

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

Judges recognize outstanding ideas. The platform recognizes outstanding leadership. Together, they recognize excellence from every level of the educational community.

Chapter 3: How Schools Become Eligible for Awards

Every participating school has the opportunity to earn recognition. Unlike student scholarships, School Awards are not determined by a panel of judges. The platform evaluates verified participation and engagement throughout the competition period so every school is measured using the same objective standards.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand how schools qualify for recognition. - Learn what activities contribute to School Awards. - Recognize the role of principals, teachers, and students.	- Schools compete through participation and engagement. - Student project quality alone does not determine School Awards. - Every verified student strengthens the school's standing.

How the Platform Evaluates Schools

- Student participation: eligible students who register and actively participate.
- Completed student projects: students who submit required materials before the deadline.
- Teacher participation: registered teachers who support and monitor students.
- School leadership participation: dashboard activation, communication, and support.
- Overall school engagement: verified activity across the competition period.

IMPORTANT NOTICE

The exact scoring algorithm, weighting formulas, and internal calculations remain proprietary. Every participating school is evaluated using the same standardized methodology.

Chapter 4: Every Student Strengthens Their School

One of the primary goals of the challenge is to encourage schools to create opportunities for as many students as possible. Every verified student who participates represents another young person learning how to research, communicate professionally, solve problems, and contribute to the community.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand why student participation matters. - Recognize how participation supports school recognition. - Promote equal opportunity for every eligible student.	- Every verified student contributes to overall participation. - Participation encourages real-world learning and community engagement. - Every student has something valuable to contribute.

Every Student Matters

Not every student will earn a scholarship, but every participating student gains experience by interviewing businesses, identifying real challenges, developing solutions, and presenting ideas. This experience benefits the student, strengthens the school, and supports the broader mission of preparing future leaders.

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

A school's greatest achievement is not simply producing one outstanding student - it is creating an environment where every student believes they can make a difference.

Chapter 5: School STEM Award

The School STEM Award recognizes the school that demonstrates outstanding student participation, teacher engagement, and school-wide commitment to innovation and community problem-solving. The award is intended to strengthen STEM education, entrepreneurship, and future-ready learning opportunities.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Define the School STEM Award. - Explain what the award recognizes. - Clarify that it is platform-calculated.	- The award recognizes school-wide opportunity. - It is not determined by judges. - Verified participation and engagement data drive eligibility.

What the Award Supports

- STEM education
- Robotics and technology programs
- Artificial Intelligence learning
- Engineering and entrepreneurship initiatives
- Innovation labs and student learning experiences
- Career readiness programs

DETERMINED BY

The Official Competition Platform using verified participation and engagement data.

Chapter 6: Principal Leadership Award

The success of a school begins with leadership. The Principal Leadership Award recognizes principals and school leaders who create an environment where students are encouraged to think critically, solve real-world problems, and participate in meaningful educational experiences beyond the classroom.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand the purpose of the Principal Leadership Award. - Learn how principals contribute to school success. - Promote active leadership involvement.	- Principals are not judged by the quality of student ideas. - Leadership is evaluated through verified platform activity. - Every participating school has an equal opportunity to qualify.

Examples of Leadership Activity

- Claiming and maintaining the official School Dashboard.
- Encouraging teacher participation.
- Promoting student involvement.
- Supporting school-wide engagement.
- Celebrating student participation and achievement.

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

Great schools are built through great leadership. The award recognizes leaders who create opportunities for students and teachers to thrive.

Chapter 7: Teacher Impact Award

Teachers inspire curiosity, encourage participation, and help students discover talents they may not realize they have. The Teacher Impact Award recognizes educators who encourage real-world learning, community problem-solving, and innovation through the challenge.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain the purpose of the Teacher Impact Award. - Clarify how teachers contribute to student success. - Distinguish teacher recognition from student judging.	- Teachers are not judged by student creativity or project quality. - Independent judges do not evaluate teachers. - The platform calculates Teacher Impact Awards using verified participation data.

Examples of Teacher Involvement

- Encouraging students to register.
- Helping students prepare for business interviews.
- Monitoring student progress through the Teacher Dashboard.
- Motivating students to complete and submit projects.
- Celebrating participation regardless of competition results.

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

The Teacher Impact Award honors educators who open doors for students and help many students discover their potential.

Chapter 8: The Role of Independent Judges

The responsibilities of Official Judges and the Official Competition Platform are intentionally separated. Official Judges evaluate student submissions only. The platform calculates School Awards, Principal Awards, and Teacher Awards using verified participation and engagement data.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain the responsibilities of Official Judges. - Clarify which awards are determined by judges. - Promote confidence in the fairness of the competition.	- Judges evaluate students only. - Judges do not score schools, principals, or teachers. - Platform-generated awards are calculated separately from judging.

Responsibilities of Official Judges

- Evaluate student submissions using the official rubric.
- Score creativity, innovation, research, problem-solving, practicality, community impact, and presentation.
- Apply the same standards to every assigned submission.

Judges Do Not

- Select winning schools.
- Select winning principals.
- Select winning teachers.
- Determine School Award rankings.
- Influence platform award calculations.

Chapter 9: Student Success and School Success

Student achievement and school achievement are recognized independently. A school does not need to produce the highest-scoring student to earn the School Award, and a student may receive a scholarship even if their school does not receive a School Award.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain why student and school awards may have different recipients. - Reinforce transparency in the competition. - Help schools understand how every student contributes.	- Student scholarships do not automatically determine the School Award. - A School Award does not require the highest-scoring student. - Participation and leadership are evaluated separately from student project quality.

Example Outcomes

- A school may produce the highest-scoring student without receiving the School Award.
- A school may earn the School Award through outstanding participation even without a first-place scholarship winner.
- Both results are valid because each award measures a different achievement.

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

A single outstanding project can change a student's future. A school that inspires broad participation can change the future of an entire community.

Chapter 10: Building a Winning School Strategy

Schools that perform well typically create an environment where students are encouraged to participate, teachers work together, and school leadership actively supports the initiative. A coordinated approach creates more opportunities for students and educators alike.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Understand how schools can encourage participation. - Learn the roles of principals, teachers, students, and families. - Create a school-wide approach.	- Success begins with leadership. - Teacher involvement increases participation. - Every completed project contributes to school impact.

Recommended Strategy

Group	Recommended Actions
School Leadership	Claim the dashboard, introduce the challenge, encourage grade-level participation, and celebrate student involvement.
Teachers	Introduce the challenge, answer general questions, monitor progress, and celebrate completed projects.
Students	Register, conduct interviews professionally, develop original solutions, and submit work before the deadline.
Parents and Guardians	Encourage students, support scheduling and transportation, and review safety expectations without completing the work.

Chapter 11: Why the Competition Uses an Automated Award System

School, Principal, and Teacher Awards are not selected by judges, sponsors, school administrators, or Competition Administration. The platform evaluates verified participation and engagement data using standardized criteria applied equally to every participating school.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain why awards are platform-calculated. - Promote confidence in fairness. - Clarify the difference between objective calculations and subjective judging.	- The platform uses the same standards for every school. - Awards are not based on personal opinions. - Automation supports consistency and equal treatment.

Why Automation Matters

Educational competitions should be built on trust. By using an automated evaluation system for School, Principal, and Teacher Awards, the competition minimizes subjectivity and applies the same measurable standards to every participating school.

TRANSPARENCY AND SECURITY

Schools are informed of participation categories that contribute to recognition. The platform's proprietary algorithms and weighting formulas remain confidential to protect fairness and security.

Chapter 12: School Award Eligibility Requirements

Eligibility begins with participation. Recognition is earned through verified engagement and compliance with official competition requirements. Schools should prepare before the competition begins so students, teachers, and administrators have the greatest opportunity to participate successfully.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain minimum award eligibility requirements. - Clarify responsibilities of schools, principals, teachers, and students. - Promote consistency across schools.	- Schools must complete official registration. - Principals should claim the School Dashboard. - Only verified participation is included in platform evaluation.

General Eligibility Requirements

- School registration or profile claim through the official platform.
- Principal or authorized administrator activation of the School Dashboard.
- Teacher registration and use of the Teacher Dashboard where applicable.
- Eligible student registration and submission of original work before the deadline.
- Verification of participation and compliance.

VERIFICATION RULE

Incomplete, duplicate, fraudulent, or disqualified submissions do not contribute toward School, Principal, or Teacher Award eligibility.

Chapter 13: Defining Success

Success can be achieved in many different ways. Awards provide recognition, but the deeper purpose of the competition is to inspire students to think critically, solve real-world problems, and strengthen their communities through innovation and leadership.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Define what success means within the competition. - Encourage schools to focus on student growth. - Promote a long-term culture of innovation.	- Success extends beyond receiving an award. - Every participating student gains real-world experience. - Teachers and principals create lasting impact through opportunity.

A Successful School

A successful school creates opportunities for students to learn beyond the classroom, supports teachers, promotes ethical leadership, and builds relationships with local businesses and community organizations.

A Successful Teacher

A successful teacher encourages participation, challenges students to think independently, and celebrates growth throughout the learning process.

A Successful Student

A successful student identifies a real challenge, develops an original solution, and presents thoughtful recommendations with professionalism and integrity.

Chapter 14: Integrity, Fairness, and Equal Opportunity

Every participating school, principal, teacher, and student is evaluated under the same official rules and standards. No school receives preferential treatment based on size, district, funding, location, reputation, or previous participation.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Explain how fairness is maintained. - Reinforce confidence in the award process. - Protect the integrity of School, Principal, and Teacher Awards.	- Every school is evaluated using the same standards. - Sponsors do not determine award recipients. - Awards cannot be purchased, negotiated, or influenced.

What Does Not Influence Awards

- School size alone.
- School district or geographic location.
- Public, charter, private, religious, or homeschool status.
- Financial resources.
- Personal relationships.
- Sponsor involvement.
- Popularity or public voting.

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

Fairness is the foundation of credibility. Every award is earned through a transparent and consistent process.

Chapter 15: Every School Has the Opportunity to Succeed

The challenge welcomes schools of every size and community throughout New York State. The purpose of the School Award is not to reward enrollment size, but to recognize schools that actively engage students and create meaningful educational opportunities.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Reinforce equal opportunity for every school. - Explain that participation matters more than enrollment size alone. - Encourage schools of all types and sizes to participate.	- Large enrollment alone does not guarantee recognition. - Smaller schools can achieve outstanding results through engagement. - The competition values leadership and opportunity.

Opportunity Is Measured by Action

The School Award recognizes schools that actively encourage participation and create opportunities for students to engage in meaningful learning experiences. Success is built through leadership, collaboration, and student involvement - not simply by school size or reputation.

Chapter 16: Best Practices for School Participation

Schools that actively support student participation create more opportunities for students, teachers, and the school community to succeed. The best practices in this chapter help schools maximize educational engagement throughout the competition.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Help schools organize successful participation. - Encourage collaboration among leadership, teachers, students, and families. - Strengthen opportunities for recognition.	- Successful participation begins with planning. - Leadership and teacher collaboration encourage greater involvement. - Recognition is earned through verified participation and engagement.

Best Practices

- Register or claim the official School Dashboard.
- Share competition information with faculty and staff.
- Encourage participation across multiple grade levels.
- Introduce the challenge in appropriate classes or clubs.
- Encourage students to register early and schedule interviews in advance.
- Support student work without completing it for them.

OFFICIAL PRINCIPLE

The strongest schools inspire students to ask questions, solve problems, serve their communities, and believe their ideas can make a difference.

Chapter 17: Frequently Asked Questions

The following questions address common topics regarding School, Principal, and Teacher Awards and help participating schools understand how recognition is determined.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Answer common award-process questions. - Clarify responsibilities of judges and the platform. - Build confidence in transparency.	- Judges do not select schools, principals, or teachers. - Platform calculations use verified engagement data. - Separate award systems recognize different contributions.

Who decides the School Award?

The School Award is calculated by the Official Competition Platform using verified participation and engagement data.

Do judges score schools, teachers, or principals?

No. Official Judges evaluate student submissions only.

Can a school win without the highest-scoring student?

Yes. Student Scholarships and School Awards are separate recognition systems.

Can a teacher win without a scholarship winner?

Yes. Teacher Awards recognize mentorship, support, and student completion, not only scholarship results.

Can sponsors influence award recipients?

No. Sponsors support opportunity but do not select award recipients.

Why use separate award systems?

Students, teachers, principals, and schools each contribute in different ways, so each award recognizes a different kind of achievement.

Chapter 18: School Commitment to Educational Leadership

Schools that participate become part of a statewide educational initiative dedicated to expanding opportunity, encouraging innovation, and strengthening communities through student leadership. Participation reflects a commitment to meaningful learning beyond the classroom.

Objectives	Key Takeaways
- Summarize the school leadership commitment. - Reinforce the shared mission. - Close with a professional pledge.	- Schools support student participation with fairness and integrity. - Competition Administration maintains transparent procedures. - The impact extends beyond a single competition.

School Leadership Commitment

- Support student participation with fairness and integrity.
- Encourage ethical conduct throughout the competition.
- Promote creativity, innovation, and critical thinking.
- Respect the independence of judging.
- Celebrate student participation regardless of results.

Founder’s Closing Message

Thank you for believing in your students. This challenge gives students the chance to apply what they learn in the classroom to real challenges facing local businesses and communities. Together, we are helping students develop confidence, leadership, communication, creativity, and critical thinking while strengthening the communities they call home.

With gratitude, Frantz Coutard Founder, Leave It Better Than You Found It

Quick Reference Guide

Student Awards

- Determined by Independent Official Judges.
- Evaluate creativity, innovation, problem-solving, community impact, research, practicality, and presentation.
- Examples include scholarships, student recognition, internship opportunities, career opportunities, and statewide recognition.

School, Principal, and Teacher Awards

- Determined by the Official Competition Platform.
- Based on verified participation and educational engagement.
- Examples include School STEM Award, Principal Leadership Award, and Teacher Impact Award.

COMPETITION PHILOSOPHY

Students are rewarded for their ideas. Teachers are rewarded for their impact. Principals are rewarded for their leadership. Schools are rewarded for creating opportunities.

Official Publication Information

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